

```
h1 {  
font-style:italic;  
}
```

2.4 Inheritance

Inheritance describes the method by which HTML elements inherit style properties from a parent element. By not declaring a particular CSS value for the child element, that child element may in many circumstances inherit a property given to its parent element. While CSS cascades styles, HTML inherits them. Though inheritance can be a blessing for unaware developers it might turn into a curse. It has a tendency of causing confusion across multiple style sheets, especially when debugging your CSS, and it is strongly recommended that you are aware of it.

To explain inheritance, let us consider a few HTML elements as parents, and the elements within them as their children. The parent passes its properties down to the child, moving through the HTML markup, it is understood that some child elements to a certain parent element can also act as parents to other child elements and so on. This containment hierarchy is referred to as the tree. To illustrate inheritance, let's again go back to headings. The `<h1>` heading in this example is styled with a very simple rule:

```
/* Top-level heading */  
h1 {  
color:#333;  
}
```

The rule is pretty simple, and you can assume that the heading will be rendered dark gray. Now let's assume that in the HTML the markup dictates that a few of the words should be emphasized using `<em>`:

```
<h1>This is the best heading <em>in the world</em></h1>
```

At this stage, no CSS rule has been written to manipulate the `<em>` element. But the text within the `<em>` element will inherit the colour from the `h1` rule (its parent element) and will also be dark grey. To overrule this inherited colour, you can simply define the `<em>` in the style sheet:

```
/* Make emphasized text shine brightly */  
em {  
color:#F00;  
}
```